

How Pune's Saanvi Kumar won Apple's Swift Challenge

Pune's 20-year-old app maker was among the winners of Apple's prestigious Swift Challenge

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For 20-year-old Saanvi Kumar, the winner of Apple's prestigious Swift Student Challenge, coding is more than just logic and syntax -- it's a medium for creating real-world solutions that leave an impact. Currently a third year student in Chennai, Saanvi is inspiring a generation of eco-conscious kids with her award-winning app, EcoHero.

The idea for EcoHero, Saanvi's app, was rooted in her childhood experiences. Growing up, her family had a vermicomposting bin at home. "At the time, it didn't feel like a big deal," she recalls. "But over time, I realised that a small, quiet habit was teaching me something bigger: that even little actions, repeated consistently, can have a real impact."

Saanvi wanted to create a similar experience for kids. This was going to be her attempt to show them that their everyday choices matter. EcoHero uses storytelling to engage children in eco-friendly habits, transforming mundane actions into an interactive narrative.

"The hardest part was figuring out how to make those everyday moments come alive in the app," she shares. "It wasn't just about making questions, it was about creating a story that felt natural and relatable."

Her dedication to understanding user needs and creating a meaningful experience paid off. EcoHero stood out



Saanvi Kumar

in the Swift Student Challenge for its clarity, creativity, and intention.

Early influence

Saanvi's tryst with coding began in her school days with simple exercises like identifying palindrome numbers and solving Armstrong number puzzles. "It was basic, but it gave me this sense of clarity and structure," she says. "I loved how logical it was and how there was always a way to break a problem down and solve it step by step."

These early encounters with problem-solving planted the seeds of her interest in technology. However, it wasn't until her college years that Saanvi truly grasped the transforma-

tive potential of technology. "That shift in perspective - from solving puzzles to solving problems that matter - is what really deepened my interest," she shares.

She shares that there was a heavy focus on academics in her childhood. "It was very by-the-book," she says. "I focused a lot on exams and theory, which helped me build a strong foundation in computer science." But it wasn't until she moved to Chennai for college that her mindset truly shifted. Being exposed to a diverse mix of people and perspectives ignited her creativity and broadened her horizons.

"Chennai taught me to observe more, to look at my environment, and to think in terms of real-world solutions," she explains. "It challenged the way I used to think and helped me evolve, not just technically but personally. I learned to step out of my comfort zone and grow as a creator."

Balancing academics and exploration

Saanvi's journey is a testament to how structured learning and independent exploration can complement each other. "For me, academics and independent learning were never on opposite sides," she explains. "The more I explored things on my own, the more meaning I found in what I was learning in class and vice versa." She recounts moments when building a side project